

HIV and AIDS

HIV stands for human immunodeficiency virus. It attacks the immune system and weakens the body's ability to fight infection and disease. HIV is most often spread by unprotected sex, but can also be transferred by sharing contaminated needles, or by some types of bodily fluid being transferred between an infected person and another. This is because HIV can be passed via breast milk, blood, semen, and discharge from the vagina and anus. It doesn't affect saliva, sweat, or urine, and can't survive independently outside the body.

There is no cure for HIV, but doctors can prevent it from developing into AIDS (acquired immune deficiency syndrome) with early diagnosis and treatment. AIDS is the last stage of HIV, when the immune system is severely damaged and the body is vulnerable to life-threatening infections.

GOOD TO KNOW

Symptoms of HIV

- Chronic fatigue and joint pain
- Coughing and shortness of breath
- Diarrhea
- Sore throat
- Fever, chills, and night sweats
- Nausea and vomiting
- Sores in the mouth or genitals; rash
- Weight loss

STD testing

Going to a sexual health clinic regularly is good practice, as some STDs don't have symptoms. If a teen has had unsafe sex, or if they are concerned they may have an STD, it's essential to book an appointment with a doctor or at the clinic as soon as possible.

Sexual health clinics are confidential and available to everyone of all genders or ages. The results of some tests may be available right away, but others might take a few weeks to come through. If the results indicate an infection, treatment will be given, and a teen's partner should be informed, as well as any previous partners, if possible.



GOOD TO KNOW

What to expect

An STD screening might involve a blood or urine test, a sample from the urethra or the vagina, or a genital examination. You'll also be asked some questions:

- Why do you think you might have an STD?
- When did you last have sex, and have you ever had unprotected sex?
- What symptoms do you have, if any?

◀ Worth the embarrassment

It's normal to feel apprehensive before going in for an STD test, but getting checked regularly ensures people stay safe and healthy.